

Approaches to managing conflict

Day 2 · Session 1 | Both sectors | Shared resource

Work through these six scenarios with a partner — ideally someone from the other sector. They are fictional and deliberately ordinary: the point is to practise the diagnosis on easy material before applying it to anything that matters to you.

Quick Reference: The Four Approaches

Approach	Detail
Power	The outcome is determined by who can force it
Rights	The outcome is determined against an objective standard — a law, an agreement, precedent
Avoidance	The dispute is never actually addressed — dropped, deferred, or one party withdraws
Consensus	The outcome is agreed between the parties, built around what each side actually needs

The Six Scenarios

Scenario A — The Night Shift Rota

A ward manager posts a revised night-shift rota on the noticeboard, moving two staff onto nights without asking them first, because — in the manager's words — “someone has to do it.” Neither staff member is consulted before the notice goes up.

Approach being used now

A better approach, and the next step

Scenario B — The Training Budget

Two departments both submit a request for the same annual training budget line. Neither request is refused. Both are simply left unanswered for two consecutive planning cycles, with everyone assuming someone else will raise it again.

Approach being used now

A better approach, and the next step

Scenario C — The Reserved Parking Bay

A senior staff member begins parking in a bay marked for visitors and continues after being asked to stop, on the grounds that seniority earns the space. Junior colleagues complain to each other, but nobody raises it with him directly.

Approach being used now

A better approach, and the next step

Scenario D — The Standing Monday Meeting

A joint consultative meeting meant to discuss workload has been rescheduled six times in two months, always by the same department. The agenda item about workload has never actually been reached.

Approach being used now

A better approach, and the next step

Scenario E — The Uniform Policy

Night-shift staff say a clause in a new dress-code notice contradicts what is written in the staff handbook. Human resources checks the handbook, confirms the staff are right, and corrects the notice within a week.

Approach being used now

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Scenario F — The Leave Cover Arrangement

Two colleagues who usually cover each other's leave disagree about whose turn it is to cover a particularly busy month. They sit down together, look at the calendar, and agree an arrangement that works for both, including a small trade for the following month.

Approach being used now

A better approach, and the next step

Question 1

Which scenario produced the sharpest disagreement between you and your partner, and what was the disagreement actually about?

Quick Reference: Designing a Better System

Keep this page after today. It is a compact version of the design principles from Part 2 of the session.

A well-designed sequence, lowest cost first

- 1. Raise it early and informally, while the issue is still small and cheap to fix.**
- 2. Use the internal grievance or joint consultative machinery — structured, but still in-house.**
- 3. Negotiate formally, with a prepared position, agreed data and a clear mandate.**
- 4. Use the appropriate formal route. Conciliation seeks an agreement; arbitration or a court determines an outcome against applicable rights and standards. Protect legal deadlines and use the procedure required for the dispute.**
- 5. Reserve lawful power as a last resort, used deliberately and never as an opening move.**
- 6. Loop back — after any rights or power step, return to the table and rebuild the working relationship.**

None of this eliminates disagreement, and that is not the goal. What it does is shift how disagreement gets resolved — away from the costliest routes, and towards the ones that leave both sides able to work together the next morning.